had an RSS background. When the BJP came back to power in 2020, Chouhan expanded his cabinet to thirty-five ministers to accommodate the Congress defectors who had made his new government possible. The new entrants constituted over one-third of the new cabinet and the proportion of ministers with an RSS background fell by almost half to 23 per cent. These numbers indicate the BJP's ability to be flexible in order to gain or retain power (see Figure 12.8).

A cadre of ex-RSS leaders is not the only form of soft power the Sangh has within the party. The real power it has is of a moral nature. The late BJP leader Pramod Mahajan, often derided by some RSS leaders as a 'lapsed' swayamsevak, used to call the RSS a 'third umpire'. The Sangh's authority, he said, also 'came from its neutrality', its strength from its 'sacrifice, from a simple lifestyle, from objectivity, from ideology'. In his view, as long as the Sangh was seen by BJP leaders to have these qualities, it would always have a moral authority.[56] As Pyarelal Khandelwal, then vice president of the BJP, told the journalist Manini Chatterjee, 'those who want to do election politics do not remain pracharaks. If he joins politics, he will have to resign, and therefore the respect for the pracharak remains intact within the parivar'.[57]

Figure 12.8: Cabinet Ministers with RSS Backgrounds Fell in Madhya Pradesh After Congress Defectors Were Given Ministerial Portfolios in 2020